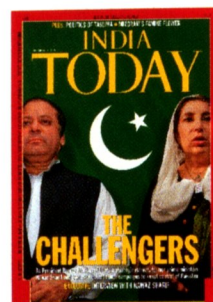


ASSOCIATED PRESS



"The Challengers",
December 10, 2007

**"Challengers to
Musharraf must also
have the power to
become the changers
of Pakistan. They
should be able to snuff
out terrorism."**

S.C. KAPOOR, *Noida*

Three-cornered Fight

Neither President Pervez Musharraf, nor the two former prime ministers have a record clean enough for general elections ("The Challengers", December 10). It is unfortunate that the people of Pakistan have to choose between them.

P. GANESHAN, *Visakhapatnam*

Nawaz Sharif and Benazir Bhutto are living in Lilliputians' paradise, mistaking Musharraf's pretensions for a felled Gulliver.

RAJNEESH BATRA, *Delhi*

His bravado and tall claims of having the right recipe for a South Asian model of democracy notwithstanding, Musharraf's original plan of keeping all power in his hands has gone awry and he has been made to eat humble pie. He has had to quit as army chief and his attempts at keeping Benazir and Sharif from

joining the political fray have not yielded the desired result.

NALINI VIJAYARAGHAVAN,
Thiruvananthapuram

To India it makes no difference whether Pakistan is ruled by a military dictator or a democratically elected government. There was no marked difference in the ties between the two countries even when Benazir and Sharif were in power.

S. LAKSHMI, *on e-mail*

The story rests on the premise that Sharif and Benazir will take on Musharraf. It overlooks certain undercurrents in Pakistan's mercurial political scenario like their seemingly tacit understanding with the current regime, the rivalry between the two leaders and the role the US is playing in the run-up to the elections.

A. JACOB SAHAYAM,
Thiruvananthapuram

Writer Wronged

Though the Government has agreed to continue playing host to exiled Bangladeshi writer Taslima Nasreen, there has been no talk about her freedom of expression as a writer ("Exiled to the Vote Bank", December 10). Her's is the tale of the death of liberalism in the country. She has every right to stay anywhere in India subject to visa restrictions.

S. K. AGGARWAL, *Amritsar*

Nasreen's interview lifts the veil off both Congress's and CPI(M)'s face, pockmarked by their pseudo-secular principles. While the Yechuries and Karats have built a false front by their verbal red herrings to shield the inhuman acts of their followers, Congress's Pranab Mukherjee has virtually gagged the writer in Nasreen.

H.R. BAPU SATYANARAYANA,
Anand

West Bengal's image as a secular and liberal state has taken a severe beating with CPI(M) forcing Nasreen to leave the state simply because fanatical hooligans who ran amok in Kolkata willed it so.

J. AKSHAY, *Secunderabad*

It would be better if the magazine refrained from using words like "paranoid religion" for Islam. Please take the trouble of reading on Islam before passing judgments based on interactions with deluded writers like Nasreen.

NILEEN PUTATUNDA,
on e-mail

Don't be so Frank

Vice-President Hamid Ansari needs to exercise restraint in his utterances as he is no longer an academic person, but one of the country's representatives ("Frankly Speaking", December 10). This article should serve as a reminder.

C.K. SARDANA, *Bhopal*